

בראשית ΓΕΝΕΣΙΣ

¹ In the beginning [בראשית · Bereshit · /be.re'ʃit/], God [אלהים · Elohim · /e.lo'him/] created [בָּרָא · bara · /ba'ra/] the heavens [שָׁמַיִם · shamayim · /ʃa'ma.jim/]¹ and the earth [אֶרֶץ · eretz · /e.rets/].

² The earth [אֶרֶץ · eretz · /e.rets/] was formless [תֹּהוּ · tohu · /'to.hu/] and empty [בוֹהוּ · bohu · /'bo.hu/]². Darkness [חֹשֶׁךְ · choshekh · /'xo.ʃex/] was on the surface of the deep [תְּהוֹמִים · tehom · /te'hom/], and God's Spirit [רוּחַ אֱלֹהִים · ruach Elohim · /ru.ax e.lo'him/] was hovering [מְרַחֶפֶת · merachefet · /me.ra'xe.fet/] over the surface of the waters [מַיִם · mayim · /'ma.jim/].

³ God [אלהים · Elohim · /e.lo'him/] said, “Let there be light, and there was light [יְהִי אוֹר וַיְהִי אוֹר · yehi or, vayhi-or · /jə'hi ʔor vaj'hi ʔor/]³.”

⁴ God [אלהים · Elohim · /e.lo'him/] saw [רָאָה · ra'ah · /ra'a/] the light [אוֹר · or · /or/], and saw that it was good [טוֹב · tov · /tov/]. God divided [בָּדַל · badal · /ba'dal/] the light from the darkness [וַיַּבְדֵּל חֹשֶׁךְ · choshekh · /'xo.ʃex/].

⁵ God [אלהים · Elohim · /e.lo'him/] called the light [אוֹר · or · /or/] “day [יוֹם · yom · /jom/],” and the darkness [חֹשֶׁךְ · choshekh · /'xo.ʃex/] he called “night [לַיְלָה · laylah · /'la.ja/].” There was evening [עֶרֶב · erev · /'e.rev/] and there was morning [בֹּקֶר · boqer · /'bo.ker/], the first day [יוֹם אֶחָד · yom echad · /jom e'xad/].

⁶ God [אלהים · Elohim · /e.lo'him/] said, “Let there be an expanse [רָקִיעַ · raqia · /ra'ki.a/] in the middle of the waters [מַיִם · mayim · /'ma.jim/], and let it divide the waters from the waters.”

⁷ God [אלהים · Elohim · /e.lo'him/] made [עָשָׂה · asah · /a'sa/] the expanse [רָקִיעַ · raqia · /ra'ki.a/], and divided the waters [מַיִם · mayim · /'ma.jim/] which were under the expanse from the waters which were above the expanse; and it was so [כֵּן · ken · /ken/].

⁸ God [אלהים · Elohim · /e.lo'him/] called the expanse [רָקִיעַ · raqia · /ra'ki.a/] “sky [שָׁמַיִם · shamayim · /ʃa'ma.jim/].” There was evening [עֶרֶב · erev · /'e.rev/] and there was morning [בֹּקֶר · boqer · /'bo.ker/], a second day [יוֹם שֵׁנִי · yom sheni · /jom ʃe'ni/].

⁹ God [אלהים · Elohim · /e.lo'him/] said, “Let the waters under the sky [שָׁמַיִם · shamayim · /ʃa'ma.jim/] be gathered together [יִקָּווּ · yiqqavu · /ji.ka'vu/] to one place, and let the dry land [יַבָּשָׁה · yabashah · /ja.ba'ʃa/] appear”; and it was so.

¹⁰ God [אלהים · Elohim · /e.lo'him/] called the dry land [יַבָּשָׁה · yabashah · /ja.ba'ʃa/] “earth [אֶרֶץ · eretz · /e.rets/],” and the gathering together [מִקְוֵה · miqveh · /mik've/] of the waters [מַיִם · mayim · /'ma.jim/] he called “seas [יָמִים · yammim · /ja'mim/].” God saw that it was good [טוֹב · tov · /tov/].

¹ In the beginning, God created the heavens and the earth.

² The earth was formless and empty. Darkness was on the surface of the deep and God's Spirit was hovering over the surface of the waters.

³ God said, “Let there be light,” and there was light.

⁴ God saw the light, and saw that it was good. God divided the light from the darkness.

⁵ God called the light “day”, and the darkness he called “night”. There was evening and there was morning, the first day.

⁶ God said, “Let there be an expanse in the middle of the waters, and let it divide the waters from the waters.”

⁷ God made the expanse, and divided the waters which were under the expanse from the waters which were above the expanse; and it was so.

⁸ God called the expanse “sky”. There was evening and there was morning, a second day.

⁹ God said, “Let the waters under the sky be gathered together to one place, and let the dry land appear;” and it was so.

¹⁰ God called the dry land “earth”, and the gathering together of the waters he called “seas”. God saw that it was good.

¹ Shamayim - the celestial-sphere hypothesis. שָׁמַיִם (shamayim, “heavens”) has a form associated with Hebrew dual morphology. Alexander Ferrari Miller proposes that an ancient understanding of the word may have associated its apparent duality with two complementary halves of the celestial sphere: the sky above the observer and the corresponding sky below the horizon. Comparative Semitic evidence shows that the word is inherited from a much older Semitic form; this is an interpretive hypothesis, not an established etymology.

² Tohu va-bohu. תֹּהוּ וָבוֹהוּ (tohu va-bohu) pairs two unusual Hebrew terms. Tohu occurs elsewhere in the Hebrew Bible, while bohu is exceptionally rare. The final scholarly note will cite the specific occurrences and distinguish established lexical evidence from interpretation.

³ Yehi or, vayhi-or. יְהִי אוֹר וַיְהִי אוֹר (yehi or, vayhi-or) is exceptionally terse and symmetrical. Yehi means “let there be” or “let it be”; or means “light”; and vayhi means “and there was” or “and it came to be.” The command and its fulfillment differ by remarkably little in Hebrew. Its poetic concision might be felt in English as something like “Shine - and shine was,” not as a translation, but as an illustration of the immediacy and economy of the Hebrew.